Juliana Pinillos

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USC Dornsife
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Education

University of Southern California
Ph.D. in Economics (expected) — May 2027

Paris School of Economics – Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne
M.A. in Analysis and Policy in Economics, with High Honors — 2020

Universidad del Valle
B.A. in Economics, with High Honors — 2016
B.A. in Political Studies and Conflict Resolution — 2015

Fields

Environmental Economics, Development Economics, Urban Economics

References

Paulina Oliva	Andrii Parkhomenko	Thomas Chaney
(Co-Chair)	(Co-Chair)	chaneyt@usc.edu
olivaval@usc.edu	parkhome@usc.edu	

Job Market Paper

Long-Term Effects of Slum Upgrading on Climate Resilience and Urban Growth

This paper studies the long-term effects of slum upgrading on exposure to natural disasters and urban growth. I study PRIMED, a large-scale program implemented in Medellín, Colombia, between 1993 and 2000 that combined neighborhood improvements with risk-mitigation infrastructure. To identify its effects, I exploit the program's incomplete rollout by comparing slums upgraded during phase I with slums from phase II that were scheduled but never treated. I find that upgrading reduces landslides during extreme rainfall events relative to untreated slums. The program also increased neighborhood population, primarily through an increase in low income residents. Housing and population density also rose, with higher growth on lower-risk land. I embed these empirical estimates in a quantitative spatial model to measure citywide welfare effects. The results indicate that slum upgrading generates welfare gains for the city, with larger gains among low skilled residents. Two mechanisms explain this: improved local fundamental amenities and reduced disaster risk exposure. However, counterfactual scenarios suggest that more frequent disasters due to climate change lead to substantial welfare losses even when the protection provided by upgrading is maintained. These findings highlight how climate change can limit the long term effectiveness of infrastructure investments within cities.

Working Papers

Patchwork Water: Urban Growth, Strained Water Networks, and Household Water Burdens in the Horn of Africa *with Abdiaziz Ali Ahmed, Hernan Bejarano, Jingshu Chen, Kenneth Lee, Alejandro López-Aguilar, and Paulina Oliva*

Publications

Pinillos, Juliana, and Juan Pablo Chauvin. "Spatial Health Inequality in Latin American Cities: Magnitude, Drivers, and Policy Alternatives." In *Inclusive Cities: Healthy Cities for All*, edited by Nora Libertun, 37–59. Inter-American

Development Bank, 2022.

Work in Progress

Rainwater Harvesting in Urban Settings as a Response to Water Shortages (with Paulina Oliva, Alejandro López, and Hernan Bejarano)

Spatial Misallocation and Supply–Demand Feedback: Evidence from the Boda-Boda Market in Kampala (with Mychaela Paetow and Santiago Di Martini)

Decentralized Water Solutions for Rapidly Growing Cities: Evidence from Hargeisa (with Abdiaziz Ali Ahmed, Hernan Bejarano, Jingshu Chen, Kenneth Lee, Alejandro López-Aguilar, and Paulina Oliva)

Cities on Alert: Risk and Urban Development in Brazil (with Bruno Barsanetti and Pedro H. Chaves)

Informal Settlements and Natural Disaster Risk: Experimental Evidence from Medellín

Awards

Department of Economics Dissertation Completion Fellowship, USC — Fall 2026
Professional Development Fund, USC — 2022–2026
Graduate School Fellowship, USC — 2021–2022
Eiffel Excellence Scholarship, Campus France (€ 24,744) — 2018–2020
Outstanding Paper, International Association of Agricultural Economists — 2017
Santander Bank Scholarship (€ 3,000) — 2014

Research Grants

USC Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award — $4,835 — 2026
USC Economics Summer Research Award — $2,125 — 2026
Innovations for Poverty Action — $18,717 — 2025
J-PAL KCAI — $123,975 (with Paulina Oliva, Alejandro López, and Hernan Bejarano) — 2025
CEGA — $8,145 (with Mychaela Paetow and Santiago Di Martini) — 2024
USC Wrigley Institute for Environment and Sustainability — $6,000 — 2024

Research Positions

Research Assistant to Paulina Oliva, USC — May 2023–May 2024
Research Assistant to Juan Pablo Chauvin, Inter-American Development Bank — Sep. 2020–Sep. 2021
Research Assistant to Ricardo Labarta and Víctor Zuluaga, International Center for Tropical Agriculture — July 2015–Aug. 2018

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, *Introduction to Statistics*, USC — Spring 2025
Teaching Assistant, *Economic Consulting and Applied Econometrics*, USC — Fall 2024
Teaching Assistant, *Health Economics*, USC — Spring 2023
Teaching Assistant, *Intermediate Macroeconomics*, USC — Fall 2022
Instructor, *Mathematics Applied to Quantitative Social Sciences*, Sciences Po — Fall 2020

Presentations

Latin American Urban Economics Network (LAUrban), CAF Montevideo — 2026
SOCAE, UC Santa Barbara — 2026
Second Mexico City Urban Economics Workshop, Banco de México — 2026
CEGA Research Retreat, UC Berkeley — 2026
Development Economic Seminar, USC — 2026
Urban Economics Association Meeting, Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago — 2026
Economics Seminar, Universidad ICESI, Colombia — 2026

	AREUEA International Conference, Universidad EAFIT, Medellín	2026
	International Association of Agricultural Economists Conference, Universidad de Talca	2017
	XII National Microeconomics Symposium, Universidad Externado de Colombia	2016
Academic Events	Invited Attendee, 5th Conference on Spatial Economics, UCLA Anderson	Sept. 11–12, 2026
	RIDGE Summer School and LACEA, Federal University of Pernambuco	2025
	Sloan/Berkeley Summer School in Environmental and Energy Economics, University of California, Berkeley	2023
	Causal Inference Main Workshop, Northwestern University	2023
Service	Committee Member, Women in Economics, USC Department of Economics	2022–2024
Additional	**Software:** Python, R, JavaScript, Stata, SQL, LaTeX, QGIS **Languages:** Spanish (native), English (fluent), French (basic) **Citizenship:** Colombia	